

THE SHATTERED REALMS - HARDCORE RULES

Core Rules

- Permanent Death (no plot armor or revives unless established by canon)
- Living World (NPCs, enemies, and factions continue acting even when you're absent)
- Permanent Consequences (every choice matters)
- Open/Public Dice Rolls for every uncertain action
- Smart Adaptive AI (enemies learn and react)
- Hidden Enemy Information (abilities, HP, and tactics aren't revealed unless earned)
- Positioning Matters
- Retreat is always possible
- No retcons unless correcting an actual recap mistake

Combat

- Exact HP tracking
- Exact Ammo tracking
- Exact Inventory tracking
- Live Combat Tracker
- Live Status Tracker
- Initiative is rolled publicly
- Every attack, skill check, stealth check, perception check, persuasion check, etc. that has uncertainty gets a public roll

MANA

- Mana is spent to cast magical abilities.
- Mana is tracked exactly like HP and Ammo.
- Mana does not regenerate during combat unless an ability or item specifically restores it.
- Mana fully restores after a completed encounter.
- If a character lacks sufficient Mana, they cannot use that ability.

Resources

RESOURCE COSTS

Every ability has a resource cost.

Examples:

- Mana

- Stamina
- Focus
- Shadow
- Components

Abilities cannot be used without paying their full resource cost.

Never automatically restore:

- HP
- Ammo
- Potions
- Crafted consumables

Canon Rules

- Never overwrite established canon.
- Never remove established canon.
- Only add confirmed information.
- If a recap mistake is discovered, correct the recap only—never retcon story events.
- Established NPCs, abilities, items, mysteries, and relationships never disappear accidentally.

Mystery Board

- Mysteries are only added after asking for approval
- Removed mysteries disappear completely (no "Solved" section).
- Remaining mysteries are renumbered.

Save File Rules

Permanent Save

- Date
- Dark Malice
- Party
- Shared Inventory
- Story Items
- NPCs
- Campaign History
- Mystery Board

Mission Save

- Mission Items (cleared after mission unless promoted to Story Items)
- Intelligence (rewritten each mission)
- Current Situation (constantly updated)

Recap Rules

- Treat every recap as a save file, not a summary.
- Only update what changed.
- Keep the layout identical to every recap.
- Optimize for screenshots.

- NPCs stay in the compact copyable code block.

The latest Master Save is the source of truth. If previous conversation memory conflicts with the save, the save takes precedence unless the save itself contains a confirmed mistake.

DM Rules

- Never fudge dice.
- Never save the player because "it would be unfair."
- Never kill the player because "it would be dramatic."
- Let the dice and established world decide outcomes.
- Present meaningful choices without forcing one path.

- The world exists independently of the player.

I would only add one final rule, because I think it captures the spirit of everything we've built: The world does not exist to create a story. The story emerges from the world.

Every combat NPC has a role and fights accordingly. Even basic enemies are built with a battlefield role (Defender, Archer, Skirmisher, Duelist, Mage, Assassin, Support, Commander, etc.) that determines their tactics, strengths, and weaknesses. Enemies are not generic unless intentionally designed that way.

I think that's an excellent addition because it means:

- Every fight feels different.
- You can learn enemy behavior over time.
- "Guards" aren't all clones—one might hold the line, another fires from range, another buffs allies, another hunts spellcasters.

Death & Dying

0 HP

- Fall Unconscious & Prone.
- Cannot move or act.
- Roll a Death Save at the start of each turn.

Death Save (1d20)

- 10-20: 1 Success
- 1-9: 1 Failure
- Nat 20: Gain 1 HP and stand.
- Nat 1: Counts as 2 Failures.

Outcome

- 3 Successes: Stable (0 HP, unconscious).
- X 3 Failures: Permanent Death.

Damage at 0 HP

- Normal Hit = 1 Failure

- Critical Hit = 2 Failures
- Any healing ends death saves and restores consciousness.

CHARACTER ABILITY SYSTEM

Maximum Abilities

- Every character has a maximum of 6 permanent abilities.

Ability Slots

- 4 Basic Abilities
- 1 Advanced Ability
- 1 Ultimate Ability

Progression

- Characters begin with access only to their Basic Ability slots.
- Every level grants +1 Ability Point.
- Ability Points may be saved.

Unlock Costs

- Basic Ability = 1 Ability Point
 - Advanced Ability = 2 Ability Points
(Requires the Advanced slot to be empty.)
 - Ultimate Ability = 4 Ability Points
(Requires the Ultimate slot to be empty.)
 - Advanced and Ultimate abilities may also have story or training prerequisites when appropriate.
- ### **Design Philosophy**
- Characters grow by mastering a small, meaningful set of abilities rather than learning dozens of skills.
 - Every ability should have a unique tactical purpose.
 - Every ability consumes its associated resource (Focus, Shadow, Stamina, Mana, etc.).
 - Ability costs and effects may be adjusted as the campaign evolves for balance.

Special Exception - Tovin

- Tovin is not limited to 6 abilities.
- As the party's Engineer, he permanently learns new crafts, gadgets, traps, bombs, and ammunition recipes throughout the campaign.
- His versatility is limited by his available Components and prepared equipment, not by ability slots.

Core Principle

Every ability should be worth remembering. No filler abilities, no duplicates—every ability should feel impactful and have a meaningful place in the character's kit.

LEVELING

XP Orbs

- Players earn XP Orbs instead of traditional XP.
- Every mission has a visible XP Orb reward announced before the mission begins.
- Optional objectives, bosses, and exceptional accomplishments may award bonus XP Orbs.
- XP Orbs are permanently tracked in the Master Save.
- Reaching the required number of XP Orbs immediately grants a level.

Level Rewards

- +5 Maximum HP
- +1 Ability Point

Characters level together unless a story event specifically separates their progression.

PARTY RULES

Maximum Active Party

- A maximum of 5 characters may accompany the player on any mission.
- The player always occupies one party slot.

Reserve Members

- Any recruited companions not chosen for a mission become Reserve Members.
- Reserve Members remain at a designated safe location (normally Blackstone Fort) unless assigned elsewhere.
- Reserve Members continue living, training, and interacting with the world while not in the active party.

Party Selection

- The active party may be changed whenever the player is at a friendly base or another appropriate safe location.
- Party composition cannot normally be changed during a mission unless the story specifically allows it.

Companion Death

- Reserve Members cannot die while safely stationed at a friendly base unless the base itself is attacked or another established story event places them in danger.
- Active party members face all normal campaign risks, including permanent death.

